

D263

Frameworks for Strategic Decision-Making

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

Complaints about late deliveries have doubled at a furniture retailer with 22 stores. The ops manager asks why: trucks leave late. Why? Loading starts late. Why? Orders reach the warehouse after the cutoff. Why? The order system sends orders to the warehouse only once a day. The retailer's delivery trucks were repainted last year. Where should the team act?

- A. Change the order system to send orders to the warehouse more often.
- B. Refresh the truck branding to improve customer perception.
- C. Add more trucks so late loads can still leave on time.
- D. Pay loaders overtime to speed up loading.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A hospital quality team, led by a nurse with 25 years of experience, wants to brainstorm every possible cause of long emergency room waits and sort them into categories such as people, methods, equipment, and environment. The ER was renovated in 2022. Which tool fits?

- A. A fishbone (Ishikawa) diagram.
- B. A Pareto chart.
- C. The 5 Whys alone.
- D. A stakeholder power/interest grid.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

An online retailer with a 4.6-star rating logged 1,000 returns last quarter: wrong size 520, damaged in shipping 230, not as pictured 150, late arrival 60, other 40. Using Pareto analysis, which causes together account for 75% of returns?

- A. Late arrival and other.
- B. Wrong size and damaged in shipping.
- C. Wrong size, damaged in shipping, and not as pictured.
- D. Wrong size alone.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A help desk receives 2,000 tickets a month. Three of its 15 ticket categories produce 80% of them. How many tickets come from the other 12 categories combined?

- A.** 33
- B.** 400
- C.** 133
- D.** 1,600

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A company with 8,000 employees plans to move its call center overseas. Its board of directors has high power but little day-to-day interest in call center operations. The board meets in a historic building downtown. On a power/interest grid, how should the project team manage the board?

- A.** Keep informed.
- B.** Manage closely.
- C.** Monitor.
- D.** Keep satisfied.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

On a power/interest grid, a project team decides to keep a stakeholder group informed. Which group fits?

- A.** Regulators with veto power who follow the project closely.
- B.** The board of directors.
- C.** Call center employees, who care deeply but have little say.
- D.** The general public, with little interest or power.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A team at a regional bank with 30 branches compares two software vendors. Weights: cost 50%, ease of use 30%, support 20%. Vendor A scores 6, 9, and 8; Vendor B scores 9, 5, and 7 (out of 10). Vendor B's sales rep played college baseball. Which vendor wins, and with what weighted score?

- A. Vendor A, 7.3.
- B. Vendor B, because its rep builds the stronger relationship.
- C. Vendor A, 23.
- D. Vendor B, 7.4.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In a weighted matrix, cost is weighted 40% and quality 60%. Vendor C scores 8 on cost and 6 on quality. Vendor D scores 5 on cost. What quality score does Vendor D need to tie Vendor C?

- A. 9.5
- B. 6.8
- C. 9
- D. 8

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A project manager at a hospital with a new cafeteria wants nurses to adopt a new handoff checklist. She points out that 9 of the 10 other units already use it and that their nurses report fewer missed items. Which influence principle is she using?

- A. Scarcity.
- B. Authority.
- C. Social proof.
- D. Liking, built through the new cafeteria.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A supply chain analyst at a company that ships to 40 countries reviews 18 months of data and notices that every time fuel prices rose, shipping delays rose the next month. She concludes that delays will likely rise after this month's fuel spike. The analyst recently moved to the Denver office. What kind of reasoning is this?

- A. Inductive reasoning.
- B. Proof that fuel prices cause delays.
- C. Abductive reasoning.
- D. Deductive reasoning.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which argument is deductive?

- A. Sales rose each of the last six Decembers, so they will rise this December.
- B. Our last merger went well, and this deal is similar, so it will go well too.
- C. All contracts over \$1 million need board approval. This contract is \$1.4 million. So it needs board approval.
- D. Most vendors that miss one deadline miss others, so this vendor probably will.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

To cut costs, the purchasing team at a manufacturer with 4 plants switches to a cheaper bolt supplier and saves \$80,000 a year. Six months later, rework and warranty claims rise by \$150,000 a year. The plants' union contract was renewed in the same period. What does this show?

- A. Proof that cost-cutting is always a mistake.
- B. A failure of systems thinking: a local saving created a \$70,000 net loss for the company.
- C. A success, because purchasing met its \$80,000 savings goal.
- D. The union contract caused the rise in claims.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

Complaints about late deliveries have doubled at a furniture retailer ~~with 22 stores~~. The ops manager asks why: trucks leave late. Why? Loading starts late. Why? Orders reach the warehouse after the cutoff. Why? The order system sends orders to the warehouse only once a day. ~~The retailer's delivery trucks were repainted last year.~~ Where should the team act?

Target word: where to act **Decides:** The deepest cause in the chain is once-a-day batching.

A	Correct	Fixes the root cause, so the later delays stop.
B	Camouflage	Answers the repainting detail, which has nothing to do with delays.
C	Dropped element	Stops at the first why and treats a symptom.
D	Adjacent category	Targets an intermediate cause, not the root.

2. Answer A Concept 2

A hospital quality team, ~~led by a nurse with 25 years of experience~~, wants to brainstorm every possible cause of long emergency room waits and sort them into categories such as people, methods, equipment, and environment. ~~The ER was renovated in 2022.~~ Which tool fits?

Target word: tool choice **Decides:** Brainstorm causes and group them by category.

A	Correct	Built to organize possible causes into categories.
B	Confusion set	Ranks causes by frequency once data exist; it does not organize a brainstorm.
C	Dropped element	Follows one causal chain but does not sort many causes into categories.
D	Adjacent category	Maps people, not causes.

3. Answer B Concept 3

An online retailer ~~with a 4.6 star rating~~ logged 1,000 returns last quarter: wrong size 520, damaged in shipping 230, not as pictured 150, late arrival 60, other 40. Using Pareto analysis, which causes together account for 75% of returns?

Target word: the vital few **Decides:** Rank and add from the top until 75% is reached.

A	Inverted operation	Picks the smallest causes (10%).
B	Correct	$520 + 230 = 750$ of 1,000 = 75%.
C	Wrong stem number	Adds the 150 and reaches 90%, beyond the 75% asked.
D	Dropped element	520 is only 52%.

4. Answer B Concept 3 • transfer

A help desk receives 2,000 tickets a month. Three of its 15 ticket categories produce 80% of them. How many tickets come from the other 12 categories combined?

Target word: solve for the trivial many **Decides:** The remaining 20% of tickets.

A	Confusion set	$400 / 12$ is the average per remaining category, not the total.
B	Correct	$20\% \times 2,000 = 400$.
C	Dropped element	$2,000 / 15$ ignores the 80/20 split and averages evenly.
D	Inverted operation	That is the 80% from the top three categories.

5. Answer D Concept 4

A company with 8,000 employees plans to move its call center overseas. Its board of directors has high power but little day-to-day interest in call center operations. ~~The board meets in a historic building downtown.~~ On a power/interest grid, how should the project team manage the board?

Target word: grid strategy **Decides:** High power, low interest.

A	Inverted operation	For low power and high interest.
B	Adjacent category	For high power and high interest.
C	Confusion set	For low power and low interest.
D	Correct	High power, low interest: meet their needs without overloading them.

6. Answer C Concept 4 • transfer

On a power/interest grid, a project team decides to keep a stakeholder group informed. Which group fits?

Target word: reverse: from strategy to stakeholder **Decides:** Keep informed = low power, high interest.

A	Adjacent category	High power and high interest: manage closely.
B	Inverted operation	High power, low interest: keep satisfied.
C	Correct	Low power, high interest.
D	Confusion set	Low and low: monitor.

7. Answer D Concept 5

A team at a regional bank with 30 branches compares two software vendors. Weights: cost 50%, ease of use 30%, support 20%. Vendor A scores 6, 9, and 8; Vendor B scores 9, 5, and 7 (out of 10). ~~Vendor B's sales rep played college baseball.~~ Which vendor wins, and with what weighted score?

Target word: winner and score **Decides:** Weighted totals: A = 7.3, B = 7.4.

A	Inverted operation	A's weighted score is correct but lower; it loses.
B	Camouflage	The rep's background is not a criterion.
C	Dropped element	Adds raw scores and ignores the weights.
D	Correct	B: $4.5 + 1.5 + 1.4 = 7.4$; A: $3.0 + 2.7 + 1.6 = 7.3$.

8. Answer D Concept 5 • transfer

In a weighted matrix, cost is weighted 40% and quality 60%. Vendor C scores 8 on cost and 6 on quality. Vendor D scores 5 on cost. What quality score does Vendor D need to tie Vendor C?

Target word: solve for a missing score **Decides:** C's weighted total is $3.2 + 3.6 = 6.8$.

A	Inverted operation	Swaps the weights: $(6.8 - 5 \times 0.6) / 0.4$.
B	Confusion set	That is C's weighted total, not D's needed score.
C	Dropped element	Uses raw totals $(8 + 6 - 5)$ and ignores weights.
D	Correct	$5 \times 0.4 = 2.0$; $(6.8 - 2.0) / 0.6 = 8$.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A project manager ~~at a hospital with a new cafeteria~~ wants nurses to adopt a new handoff checklist. She points out that 9 of the 10 other units already use it and that their nurses report fewer missed items. Which influence principle is she using?

Target word: name the principle **Decides:** Pointing to what peers are doing.

A	Adjacent category	Nothing is presented as limited.
B	Confusion set	Authority relies on experts, not peers.
C	Correct	People follow what similar others do.
D	Camouflage	The cafeteria plays no part in her appeal.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A supply chain analyst at a company ~~that ships to 40 countries~~ reviews 18 months of data and notices that every time fuel prices rose, shipping delays rose the next month. She concludes that delays will likely rise after this month's fuel spike. ~~The analyst recently moved to the Denver office.~~ What kind of reasoning is this?

Target word: type of reasoning **Decides:** Generalizing from observed cases to a probable conclusion.

A	Correct	A pattern in past data supports a likely prediction.
B	Absolute language	A pattern suggests but does not prove cause.
C	Adjacent category	Abduction infers the best explanation for one observation, not a forecast from a pattern.
D	Inverted operation	Deduction applies a general rule to reach a certain conclusion.

11. Answer C Concept 7 • transfer

Which argument is deductive?

Target word: reverse: find the deductive argument **Decides:** A general rule applied to a case gives a certain conclusion.

A	Inverted operation	Generalizes from past cases: inductive.
B	Adjacent category	An argument by analogy, which is inductive.
C	Correct	If the premises are true, the conclusion must be.
D	Confusion set	"Most" and "probably" mark an inductive argument.

12. Answer B Concept 8

To cut costs, the purchasing team at a manufacturer ~~with 4 plants~~ switches to a cheaper bolt supplier and saves \$80,000 a year. Six months later, rework and warranty claims rise by \$150,000 a year. ~~The plants' union contract was renewed in the same period.~~ What does this show?

Target word: interpret the outcome **Decides:** Net effect: $\$80,000 - \$150,000 = -\$70,000$.

A	Absolute language	The lesson is to judge the net system effect, not to avoid all cost cuts.
B	Correct	Optimizing one function hurt the whole.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out the downstream costs.
D	Camouflage	The contract timing is a coincidence in the stem.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	7	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	2	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Root cause (5 Whys)	Keep asking why until you reach a cause that, if fixed, prevents the problem from recurring; act there, not on symptoms.	Fixing the first or second “why” (a symptom) with more resources.	A chain of causes and “where should the team act?”
2	Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagram	A fishbone diagram brainstorms possible causes of one effect and sorts them into categories such as people, methods, machines, materials, and environment.	Confusing it with a Pareto chart, which ranks causes by frequency.	Brainstorming all causes and grouping them by category.
3	Pareto analysis	A few causes usually produce most of the problems (roughly 80/20); rank causes and focus on the vital few.	Spreading effort evenly, or picking the smallest categories.	Counts by cause and a target share of the total.
4	Power/interest stakeholder grid	High power, high interest = manage closely; high power, low interest = keep satisfied; low power, high interest = keep informed; low power, low interest = monitor.	Swapping “keep satisfied” and “keep informed.”	A stakeholder's power and interest described in the stem.
5	Weighted decision matrix	Multiply each score by its criterion weight and sum; the highest weighted total wins.	Adding raw scores and ignoring the weights.	Criteria with percentage weights and scores for each option.
6	Principles of influence	Social proof = others like me do it; authority = experts endorse it; scarcity = limited supply; reciprocity = returning a favor; commitment = staying consistent; liking = we say yes to people we like.	Naming authority when the appeal is to peers.	What the persuader points to: peers, experts, scarcity, or a favor.
7	Inductive vs. deductive reasoning	Deductive reasoning applies a general rule to reach a certain conclusion; inductive reasoning generalizes from observations to a probable conclusion.	Calling a pattern-based prediction deductive or a proof.	“All ... therefore” vs. “every time we observed ... so likely.”
8	Systems thinking	Optimizing one part can harm the whole; judge decisions by their net effect across functions and over time.	Declaring success because one department hit its target.	A local saving followed by costs elsewhere.

Course scope (public description): Frameworks for Strategic Decision-Making challenges students to use logistical reasoning, root cause analysis, and various problem-solving skills to drive improvement, develop relationships, influence others, and make decisions. This course addresses how to evaluate business problems, develop stakeholder-oriented solutions, and influence key stakeholders. It also promotes strategic-level thinking and connection between business disciplines to drive outcomes. There are no prerequisites.